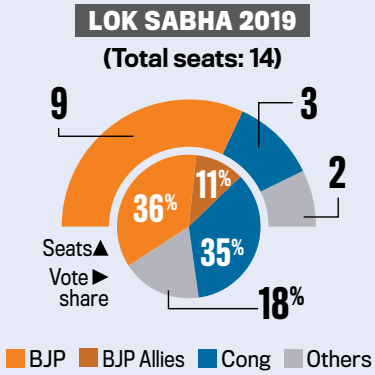


ON THE RISE

The BJP's tally went up from seven in 2014 to nine in 2019



Vote share figures have been rounded off

SARMA WON'T SETTLE FOR ANYTHING LESS THAN A WIN ON ALL 11 SEATS THAT THE BJP IS CONTESTING

Congress, which, in 2019, cornered 44 per cent of the votes against the BJP's 35 per cent. "The consolidation of Hindu votes and reduction of Muslim votes due to delimitation will ensure a smooth passage for us," admits an AGP leader, who is a minister in Sarma's cabinet.

But, more importantly, this is the first major election after Sarma took oath as chief minister in 2021, replacing Sarbananda Sonowal, who had led the BJP's campaign in 2014 and 2019. In 2014, Sarma was in the Congress. But, in 2019, his management skills and popularity played a key role in adding two more seats to the saffron kitty. If Sarma wants to prove that Sonowal, now a Union minister, is no more a player in the state's politics, he has to improve the BJP's tally. It means ensuring that not a single seat that the party won under Sonowal is lost to the rivals.

That's the reason Sarma is walking the extra mile. For instance, he spent maximum time campaigning in Jorhat, which went to the polls in the first phase and where the candidature of Gaurav Gogoi, whose fiery speeches in Parliament have earned him a steady stream of admirers, made it a tough contest for the incumbent BJP MP, Tapan Gogoi. Sarma has already announced that he will contest the next assembly election from Jorhat, which is also his birthplace, and exudes confidence in winning this Lok Sabha seat by a "margin of one to two lakh votes". Meanwhile, the rejection of the nomination of Naba Sarania, two-time independent MP from Kokrajhar—a seat reserved for Scheduled Tribes, has opened another opportunity for the NDA. The Bodo-dominated constituency will now witness a direct contest between the BJP ally UPPL and the Bodoland People's Front.

Beyond these considerations, the BJP is banking on Sarma's performance as CM. At rallies, he confidently asks crowds if he has delivered welfare benefits to them, receiving resounding affirmation. Popularly known as 'mama' (maternal uncle), he claims to have provided jobs, roads, and freedom from grassroots corruption. Steering clear of religious rhetoric, Sarma is experimenting with an outreach promising development and social uplift to expand the BJP's base. "In the last three years, most of the poor Muslims benefited from welfare schemes previously cornered by middlemen. Many are happy," says Sarma, whose trusted lieutenants predict that 20 per cent of the Muslim voters will back the BJP this time. That's a big shift from shunning the so-called 'Miya' votes. ■